became chair in March 1917. By 1918, the organisation had developed into the Eastern Committee and included members from the War, India and Foreign Offices.[40] Ostensibly, it was the Eastern Committee that was the co-ordinating body for Britain's overall strategy in places such as Persia and Mesopotamia.[41] If one is looking for where the decisions on foreign policy in this region were being made, this should have been the place. However, rather than being a place to discuss and formulate policy, the committee essentially became a vehicle for Curzon's own ego, his practice being to present to the committee draft resolutions he had already written.[42] Sir Robert Cecil (assistant secretary of state for foreign affairs) put it aptly when he complained to Balfour that the existence of the Eastern Committee seemed 'mainly to be to enable George Curzon and Mark Sykes to explain to each other how very little they know about the subject [of the East]'.[43] As will be discussed further in Chapter Two, attempts in 1918 to address the problems of coordination and organisation of Britain's affairs in this region of the world would fail, in large part because of Curzon's refusal to cooperate. Not until 1920 would a Middle Eastern Department be created, and even then Curzon would be quick to quarrel with its head, Winston Churchill, every time he felt the department to be encroaching on Foreign Office territory.[44] A number of short-lived organisations and committees would be created during this time with general remits to collect information and make policy recommendations on issues in this region which might be of importance to the British Empire.[45] Ultimately, however, when it comes to who effectively had the greatest say over foreign policy towards Persia and Afghanistan, George Nathaniel Curzon was first among equals.

## The Foreign Office Mind and Mental Maps

*It would seem then, that Curzon and his Foreign Office held ultimate sway over the creation of Britain's foreign policy towards Persia and Afghanistan, with the India Office, the War Office and the prime minister occasionally contributing to discussion and the Indian government relentlessly trying to have its voice heard, to no avail. The next question, therefore, is what factors affected the thinking of those involved in the formulation of foreign policy at this time? To answer it, we must look more*